

3.1.7 Sikhism

Students should be aware that Sikhism is one of the diverse religious traditions and beliefs in Great Britain today and that the main religious tradition in Great Britain is Christianity. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should study the beliefs, teachings and practices of Sikhism specified below and their basis in Sikh sources of wisdom and authority. They should be able to refer to scripture and/or sacred texts as appropriate. Some texts are prescribed for study in the content set out below and questions may be set on them. Students may refer to any relevant text in their answers and AQA will publish a list of appropriate texts as part of the supporting material for this specification. These additional texts will not be required for study, alternatives may be used, and questions will not be set on them.

Students should study the influence of the beliefs, teachings and practices studied on individuals, communities and societies.

Common and divergent views within Sikhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout. Students may refer to a range of Sikh perspectives in

their answers, for example to the perspective of sahajdhari and amritdhari Sikhs and the different emphases in different texts. They must study the specific differences identified below.

3.1.7.1 Beliefs and teachings

Key beliefs

- The nature of God as expressed in the Mool Mantra: the content and significance of the Mool Mantra, Guru Granth Sahib (GGS) 1a.
- God as Creator, including different aspects of God's relationship with creation:
 - God shown in and through the universe
 - God as separate from the universe
- The nature of human life as an opportunity to unite with God, including the development of Sikh virtues such as wisdom, truthful living, justice, temperance, self-control, patience, courage, humility, contentment.
- Beliefs in karma and rebirth, and the aim of mukti; the meaning of mukti, including the different aspects of mukti – positive and negative.
- The five stages of liberation (five khand) and barriers to mukti (illusion, self-centredness, lust, anger, greed, worldly attachment, pride).
- The importance of being gurmukh (God-centred) rather than manmukh (man-centred) and the elimination of pride or ego (haumai).

Beliefs about the nature of human life

- Belief in the oneness of humanity and in the equality of all, including complete equality of women with men.
- The expression of the equality of all in:
 - the stories of the lives of Gurus, including Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh
 - the Guru Granth Sahib
 - in Sikhism today.
- Sewa: the importance and priority of service to others, including physical (tan), mental (man) and material (dhan).
- The role and importance of the sangat (religious community).

3.1.7.2 Practices

Worship and service

- Religious features of the gurdwara: design, furniture, and artefacts; the practices associated with these features and their importance, including the palki and takht.
- The role of the gurdwara within the Sikh community.
- The role of prayer in the home, GGS 305:4.
- The role and importance of the akhand path.
- The meaning and significance of langar as an expression of sewa.
- The significance of meditating on the name of God (nam japna) in daily life and in the gurdwara.

Festivals and lifestyle

- Festivals and their importance for Sikhs in Great Britain today, including the origins and significance of the following:
 - Vaisakhi (Baisakhi)
 - Divali

- Gurburbs, including Guru Nanak's birthday and differences in the way gurburbs are celebrated in India and Great Britain.
- The importance of visiting Sikh historical gurdwaras, including the Golden Temple (Harimandir Sahib) in Amritsar.
- Birth and naming ceremonies including their meaning and significance.
- The initiation ceremony (Amrit Sanskar), including the meaning and importance of the Khalsa and the five Ks, and the different perspectives of sahajdhari and amritdhari Sikhs.
- The significance and use of the names Singh and Kaur.